
“ISM has been exploring opportunities to set up a research & development centre to develop intellectual property and catch up with the rest of the world on new chips and packaging technologies”

Q: The government has revised the scheme by increasing incentives for compound semiconductors, sensor fabs, and more. What's your understanding of this move?

A: As we dug into getting a better understanding of India's product needs and the global semiconductor markets India could serve in the future, it became clear that even the higher nodes and other process tech will be initially critical for the success of the India Semiconductor Mission. Once this was brought to the attention of our savvy ministers, they moved with speed and got the rules changed to ensure that all of them get a flat 50 per cent incentive [for semiconductor fabs].

In matters related to technology, it is especially crucial to have leaders who understand and appreciate the nuances of dealing with technology-related issues, to get the best outcomes in a timely way. PM (Narendra) Modi has deputed two very capable ministers—Ashwini Vaishnaw, Minister of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), and Rajeev Chandrasekhar, Minister of State for MeitY. This is the first time, as I recall, that the two ministers assigned for this crucial task have a background in technology. Furthermore, both have degrees in business.

These two government leaders quickly grasp the issues relating to the challenges we are facing and move with start-up like speed to resolve them within various ministries. I've been personally dealing with a variety of officials in the Indian government over the past four decades, but now I see a distinct positive change... a real passion and zeal to solve issues and move with speed and a 'can do' attitude. I hope this continues to be the case, independent of the ups and downs.

Q: In India, we don't have a fab ecosystem. We will have to build everything from scratch. What are the challenges we need to resolve?

A: This is a very loaded question and encompasses some of the issues that I have discussed in my meet-

